while, no frequent picnics, no increments on pocket money and no more pets in the house, except Beauty.

However, Dada and I were too young to understand any of this, and we continued to question these new developments. This left us agitated as we would often compare ourselves to the well-off kids in school. As a result, we would often argue with our parents on monetary matters. Immature as we were, we once told our parents that if given a chance, we could show them that we were better at handling finances than them. Instead of scolding us or getting angry, Maa and Papaji came up with a plan to teach us a lesson. They gave us an entire month's salary and told us to run the house for that month. Overconfident and hell-bent on proving our point, we took the amount and started to plan the expenditure. After just ten days, we almost ran out of the money they had given us. We realized our mistake and told Maa and Papaji that we had failed miserably. But instead of being angry or frustrated with us, they were content that their kids had learnt an important lesson. The same lesson would hold us in good stead later in life. I had understood the importance of the hard work Maa had been doing all this while.

As Papaji's tenure at Jabalpur crawled towards an end, Maa was almost done with her degree. One fine night, Maa invited Mrs Gupta, the teacher who had been assessing her lesson plans and assignments, over for dinner. On the same afternoon, Papaji had expressed his discontentment about Mrs Gupta's visit. He didn't like the lady because he felt she was biased and partial. The student marked first in order of merit was supposed to be given a scholarship by the university Maa had enrolled in. But despite Maa's endless efforts and excellent performance, Mrs Gupta had been partial and kept her in second place so another student, her relative, could get the scholarship. Nevertheless, humble as Maa was, she had still invited her in good faith. I had learnt about the whole matter from Dada. This filled the nine-year-old me with a lot of anger and hatred, especially as I strongly believed that the scholarship money would have helped our family. I decided to seek revenge on behalf of my mother.